

22. They are aware of the ethical challenges of technology

Ethical challenges are the new minefield in technology. Everything in technology development may look cool, but it is very likely to have some ethical angle. That means they might face significant challenges down the line.

So, is the candidate aware of those challenges? Do they understand the importance of ethics in dealing with powerful technologies? Do they have a plan or at least an idea to deal with it if that arises? How would they handle it? Ethical maturity is a new soft skill now, and almost everyone needs to have it.

23. They have a track record

A good candidate for innovation usually does not have only one celebrated win. They have a track record. They have a track record of several failures, along with a few successes. Not every win needs to be a bumper success. Some can be small, while others might be much celebrated ones.

But, in general, a good track record does have lots of failures and lots of learnings from those failures. So, check for those. Ask them if they have multiple failures? What did they learn from them? Do they have multiple smaller wins? There may be a few bumper wins, but they are not necessary to have. What you are looking for is not a one-time stroke of luck. You are looking for a track record.

24. They are resourceful

This one goes without saying. Resourcefulness is the ability to get what you want with what you have. Being resourceful is quite an important skill in innovation, business in particular. However, it is a highly revered one for every employee, in general. But specifically in innovation, you are often stranded by resources, budget, or even by lack of information.

Being a resourceful person comes in handy when resources are scarce, and the goal is important and timely.

This one is easier to check with a few exercises, scenarios, and carefully designed tests. But being a critical one, you must prioritize it when you can.

What about you?

The hiring process is not a one-way street. As much as you evaluate candidates and their fitment for your organisation, they are doing the same with you.

So, what are a few things you must do to show you are a good fit for innovative candidates?

Demonstrate. Make sure you can demonstrate company capabilities and willingness to innovate. Most of the time, companies show that they care about employee's opinions and are innovative. However, once the candidate becomes an employee, things change. They realize that it is not as rosy as the picture they were shown in the hiring process. So, you need to find ways to demonstrate your ability, willingness, culture, and approach towards innovation.

Pay: This one is straightforward and applies across the board. Top talent is seldom cheap. You often get what you pay for. So, be ready to pay for the talent. Some companies tend to think from an ROI (return on investment) perspective and calculate it that way.

I think it is a bit limiting and short-term view. It is not wrong as such, but there is more to it. When you hire candidates who are suitable for innovation, they often impact your company culture and several business practices. So, the impact they can have is beyond just an ROI.

Respect: You may hear or see it sometimes. Many strong candidates for innovation are comparatively different,

and people call them eccentric, which is an essential trait to have. Eccentricity is what makes them good at what they do. So, being respectful of their eccentricities is a must.

Listen: Even if it is too early in the process, and the candidate is not your employee yet, being receptive to their inputs and ideas can go a long way. People who are good at the innovation game appreciate someone listening to their point of view. Demonstrating that you care will instill confidence and will attract them.

Do not be offended: A lot can be told about company culture based on how people respond when they are challenged. When someone challenges your legacy, and so-called holy-cow system or process, do not be offended by it. Stay curious and dig deeper. They may have a point. At least it is worth listening to their point of view. If you feel offended, it sure sends a wrong signal and shows that you are not as flexible as you need to be for an innovative organisation. It is often a tell-tale sign for candidates not to go ahead.

The point is

You may have observed quite a bit of overlap amongst all these characteristics. But the thing is, when you are hiring people, some characteristics are useful for particular roles and not for others. Knowing what to look for besides just the hard and soft skills is very important. These are the characteristics people working in innovation should have. So, when you are hiring for innovation, these are the ones you must be looking for.

End of the day, we all must always remember that companies do not innovate; people do. **END** 🐧

By: Anand Tamboli

The author is a serial entrepreneur, speaker, award-winning author, and an emerging-technology thought leader.

The article was originally published in the November 2021 issue of Electronics For You.